

How are we to live?

Evidence-based pointers on living well

Trust, but verify

Every claim here shows **how it was tested, how big the effect is**, and its **weakest point** — and links to the paper.

- Don't be a cynic who believes nothing, or a pushover who believes everything.
- Believe things **in proportion to the evidence** — then go and check.

This whole thing assumes you care what happens next. If you don't, there's nothing here for you.

Two different clocks

10-year clock: the next ten years of your life — what could hurt you soon.

70-year clock: your whole life ahead — what builds up slowly.

10-year clock (you, now)	70-year clock (lifetime)
Don't start nicotine	Smoking
Alcohol & injury tonight	Physical inactivity
Road (belt, helmet)	Diet / food environment
Gambling on a phone	Alcohol · Gambling
Sleep & mood	Sun · Sleep

Most advice is about the 70-year clock. The two lists barely overlap.

Smoking kills — stopping helps

- Smokers die on average **~10 years** younger; two-thirds are killed by it (British Doctors Study; Banks 2015).
- **But**: stopping before 40 avoids **>90%** of the excess risk; before 30, **>97%** (Pirie 2013).
- And quitting is **achievable** — support plus medicines: varenicline more than **doubles** the chance; patches or gum raise it by about **half**.

Almost everyone who smokes for life starts young: **not starting** removes the whole problem.

Alcohol: no safe dose

- **No amount is good for you.** The "healthy glass of wine" was a mistake in the old studies — a genetic study showed it (Millwood 2019).
- **But one drink adds only a small risk.** The risk starts at the first drink and grows with each one. Say both halves, or people stop listening.
- For a teenager the danger is **tonight** — injury, not liver disease in thirty years.

Gambling: designed so you lose

No statistics needed. The **house edge** — the share of every £1 bet a game keeps, on average — is set by the company and **published**.

- Roulette keeps **2.7%** — just under 3p of every £1. Online slots keep **4-8%** of everything staked.
- You are not unlucky — you are on the wrong side of a number the company **chose and published**.
- Harm tracks the **product** (fast, continuous), not the personality.

Eat food. Mostly plants. Not too much.

- Excess body fat really **causes** type-2 diabetes, heart disease, **13 cancers** and early death (gene studies; WHO cancer agency).
- The body **defends** fat once gained, and it tracks from childhood — **prevention beats reversal**.
- You eat more when food is processed and portions are big.
Change the defaults, not your willpower.

The stakes are well-evidenced; the "right diet" is the weak part — so change the environment.

Move more, sit less

- The biggest gain is simply **leaving the least-active group** — most of the benefit comes first (Ekelund 2019).
- There is **no magic number** to hit.
- It lifts your **mood now**: being active really does lower the risk of depression (Choi 2019). Try **parkrun** — free, weekly, walk or run.

Sleep like it matters

- Best-evidenced as a **short-term** lever on mood and attention — the two weeks, not the fifty years.
- Teenage body clocks **run late** — biology, not laziness.
- Basics help: regular hours, dark room, **dim evening screens**, no late caffeine. (*Insomnia that won't go away → a proper therapy, CBT-I, not a checklist.*)

Slip, slop, slap

- The **best-tested advice** on the whole list — a proper experiment, with people split into groups by chance (Nambour).
- Daily sunscreen roughly **halved melanomas**, ten years after the trial ended.
- Melanoma is already common in **15-34s**; sunbeds are on the top list of proven causes of cancer. Both clocks agree.

Change the rules, not just yourself

The biggest gains came from the **shared environment**, not from trying harder.

- Smoke-free laws: heart-attack admissions ↓ **17%** (Scotland).
- Minimum alcohol price: alcohol deaths ↓ **13.4%**. Sugar tax: the sugar came out of the drinks.
- As you come of age, **engaging and voting** for health-promoting policy is itself a high-leverage act.

You cannot out-willpower a design.

But you can see it.

Smoking kills — stopping helps. Alcohol: no safe dose. Gambling: designed so you lose.

Eat food, mostly plants, not too much. Move more, sit less. Sleep like it matters. Slip, slop, slap.

Trust, but verify — the full evidence, with its weaknesses and links, is on the site. So is the short version: five things for your age.